

Foreign Actors
Aim to Exploit
Divide on A.I.

Campaigns to Criticize
Data Centers in U.S.

By STEVEN LEE MYERS and DUSTIN VOLZ

A state-owned newspaper in China recently published a satellite image of a data center in Gainesville, Va., writing in English that the development of artificial intelligence posed a threat to Americans' physical and financial well-being.

A comic strip made to look as if it had been published by a Maryland news outlet — created with OpenAI's ChatGPT by people in China, the tech company said — circulated on X this year, blaming data centers for soaring electricity bills. It showed a tycoon smoking a cigar and clutching bags of cash.

A video shared on X by a known covert Russian influence operation questioned the viability of a data center that an American company, Firebird, is constructing in Armenia, the small Caucasus nation that has been a focus of Kremlin pressure. "The country's electrical grid instability may render it useless," the video's narrator says.

All are examples of a push by foreign adversaries to seize on what polls have shown is deep ambivalence — verging at times on hostility — about the spread of the data centers needed to power A.I. in the United States and elsewhere.

China, Russia and, to a lesser extent, Iran have sought to use state media outlets to turn the controversy over data centers in the United States into "a domestic fracture point," according to a new analysis by Alethea, a threat intelligence company, which identified scores of articles and posts on social media this year.

These campaigns, whose impact on public opinion remains to be seen, are part of a broader effort to undermine U.S. technological leadership and create divisions within the American public.

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Graham Platner suspended his Senate campaign on Wednesday after two days of turmoil following a woman's rape accusation.

This article is by Lisa Lerer, Katie Glueck and Michael Kruse.

SULLIVAN, Maine — They told him that he was "the guy."

Last July, in a small town in coastal Maine, a couple of progressive, self-styled recruiters of economic populists showed up at the blue-shingled house of Graham Platner, a little-known oyster farmer and Marine veteran who lived largely off government benefits.

They knew his name from local labor organizers and activists, and they had watched a video on the internet of him talking about oysters. Struck by his left-leaning ideology, his working-class affect

A Maine Progressive Who Inspired Voters,
Despite a Steady Drip of Scandal

and his gravelly voice, they became convinced that he could win a Senate seat in Maine — and quickly persuaded Mr. Platner of the same.

The initial headhunters, Dan Moraff and Leanne Fan, and then a third out-of-state operative they called up to Maine — Morris Katz — told Mr. Platner he was "the one," a "hero of the movement," "a historical figure" who could be

combination of inexperienced and overconfident. The worst-case scenario, they thought, wasn't running for Senate and losing — it was destroying the life he worked hard to build.

Until recently, Mr. Platner had seemed to prove the worriers wrong. His campaign was pumping out viral videos and broadcasting scenes from crowded town halls. He easily pushed a sitting governor out of the Democratic primary as voters embraced his message of economic populism and overlooked his checkered past. Progressives across the country heralded him as a new left-wing hero and saw him as

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Aminah Knight runs a preschool and day care center in Texas.

Her 'Muslims Only' Party Flier
Led to Life-Altering Backlash

By J. DAVID GOODMAN

DALLAS — Aminah Knight had an idea two years ago to mark a major Islamic holiday by throwing an unusual party for Muslim families in the suburbs of Dallas — at an indoor water park.

The mosque she originally wanted to partner with turned her down, opposed to the idea of a swimming party to celebrate Eid al-Adha that May.

But Ms. Knight, a former public-school teacher from New York City, was determined. She wanted something for families — and especially for young women and girls who, like her, enjoyed swimming but disliked the attention that full-body swimwear, common in the Middle East, often drew at American pools.

"We swim too," Ms. Knight

Threats Over 2 Words
Before Family Swim

thought. She refused to settle for another bounce house party.

She traveled from mosque to mosque across North Texas' booming Muslim community, talking up her event. She made her own website and flier. And her efforts worked. Hundreds attended.

The water park that hosted the party worked with Ms. Knight to plan the event again last year, allowing her to rent out the entire venue. Even more people came.

So this year, as Eid approached, Ms. Knight prepared for a third installment of what was becoming an annual tradition for Dallas-

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Security Concern Forced Switch of Air Force Ones

This article is by Tyler Pager, Julian E. Barnes, Eric Schmitt and Eric Lipton.

ANKARA, Turkey — President Trump flew out of Turkey on Wednesday night on the old Air Force One instead of his new Qatari-donated Boeing 747-8 as a security precaution related to the resumption of hostilities with Iran, according to people briefed on the plans, who said the change came at the urging of the Secret Service.

The swap deepens questions about whether the new plane, which the president had pressed to be ready as soon as possible, was retrofitted with sufficient se-

A Swap Adds to Doubts
About Retrofitting of
a Jet From Qatar

curity measures over the last year. Lawmakers and some officials have raised concerns about whether the expedited timeline allowed for the addition of an advanced missile defense system and other modifications used to protect the president.

In a statement, Steven Cheung, the White House communications director, said that "the new Air

Force One is a state-of-the-art aircraft that has been fitted with high-level security protocols that ensure the safety of the president and his staff."

"As the president has said recently, there are many enemies of America who have their sights on him, and we use every tool at our disposal — including distraction and misdirection — to address those threats," he added.

But people briefed on the new plane's capabilities, who spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss sensitive security issues, said the new plane does not have

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President Trump leaving the old Air Force One in the U.K. on Wednesday after flying from Turkey.

Iran's Hubris
Could Bring
Bigger War

Taking Immense Risk
for Control of Strait

By NEIL MacFARQUHAR

Iran, fearing that its hold over the crucial Strait of Hormuz shipping lanes was gradually slipping away, risked overplaying its hand by again firing on oil tankers and potentially rekindling a major war with the United States, analysts said.

Both sides threatened on Wednesday to scuttle the Memorandum of Understanding that they had signed on June 17 to establish a blueprint for peace talks and extended a wobbly cease-fire in place since April. American warplanes carried out even more intensive attacks on scores of targets across Iran overnight, while Iran vowed to ratchet up drone and missile strikes against U.S. allies in the Persian Gulf.

The basic bargain in the vaguely worded, 14-point Memorandum of Understanding was that Iran would reopen the Strait of Hormuz for commercial shipping in exchange for badly needed economic relief. Thornier issues, including the fate of Iran's nuclear program, were kicked down the road for further negotiations. But very little changed.

"The M.O.U. increasingly looked like a mirage," said Vali Nasr, a veteran Iran analyst and a professor at the Johns Hopkins School of Advanced International Studies. "The view from Tehran is that the U.S. is engaged in a concerted effort to take control of the Strait out of Iran's hands, to weaken its position in Lebanon and to regain its own strength in order to put even more pressure on Iran or to go back to war."

As the 60-day clock on the agreement ticked away, Iran grew increasingly frustrated that the U.S. Navy was encouraging maritime traffic to take a southern route along the coast of Oman rather than respecting Iranian demands that all traffic register with its newly minted Hormuz transit authority, a precursor to charging fees. Traffic last weekend was about one-third of the prewar level of more than 100 ships daily, split evenly between the Iranian and Omani sides of the waterway, according to Kpler, which tracks marine traffic.

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Heat in France
Takes Fatal Toll
On the Chickens

By CHICO HARLAN and LÉONTINE GALLOIS

LAUBRIÈRES, France — They were meant to die, just not like this.

The chickens were 19 days away from a date at the slaughterhouse when temperatures climbed disastrously inside the long shed where they spent their nights. Over the course of several hours on June 23, during France's hottest stretch on record, 1,500 keeled over. By the time Isabelle Renaudier opened the door, one-third of the flock was dead.

"It broke my heart," said Ms. Renaudier, who had been raising the birds at her family farm in northwestern France for supermarkets, butchers and rotisseries.

Extreme heat poses a risk to nearly all living things, but chickens, unable to sweat and cloaked in feathers, are far more vulnerable than most. If temperatures climb too high, they start to pant, a

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Ivanka Trump's Fantasy Island?
The Albanian outpost in the Adriatic Sea is strewn with snakes, crumbling buildings and land mines. PAGE A4

Procession for Khamenei
Thousands were in the spiritual center of Mashhad, Iran, for the last stage of the supreme leader's funeral. PAGE A9



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Jeffries Shrugs Off Challengers
In an interview with The Times, Hakeem Jeffries, the House Democratic leader, played down the significance of a recent left-wing surge. PAGE A13

Vance Highlights Two Foes
He disparaged Democrats as "a party that is fighting for fraud," highlighting the case of a woman indicted under the Biden administration. PAGE A13

Building Inspector Cited Before
A Times review of New York City records shows that the firm overseeing a buckling building was repeatedly accused of breaking city rules. PAGE A20

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This year's boom, spurred by A.I., includes the most spent on global deal-making in a six-month period in a decade. But can it continue? PAGE B1

Footwear Duel at World Cup
Second place in the hearts and wallets of Americans isn't good enough for Nike and Adidas, who bet big on the soccer tournament. PAGE B1

Late-Night TV, but on YouTube
Julian Shapiro-Barnum, best known for a social media series called "Recess Therapy," has started an online-only late-night show. PAGE B1

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Conor McGregor reportedly continued to use illegal drugs even after recovering from a broken leg. PAGE B8

'Goooooooooooooooooall!'
The Telemundo soccer announcer Andrés Cantor must train to deliver his famed scoring celebration. PAGE B7



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The live-action remake of the animated film, with Dwayne Johnson as a demigod, offers few surprises. PAGE C1

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